

Wildfire Smoke: breathe safe, help others

Wildfire smoke carries tiny particles that enter your lungs and bloodstream. Much smoke exposure can be reduced. The two things that matter most: **stay aware of air quality** and **reduce smoke exposure indoors and out**.

MEDICAL EMERGENCY

Smoke can trigger life-threatening reactions

Call your local emergency number **immediately** if someone has chest pain, severe shortness of breath, confusion, or lips/fingernails turning blue. People with asthma or COPD should follow their emergency action plan and seek care if rescue inhalers do not help.

Air Quality Index — know the colors

The AQI tells you how dangerous the air is right now. Check an official local air-quality source when available, such as **AirNow.gov** in the U.S., your national/regional environment agency, or a trusted local weather alert service.

0–50 GREEN

Good

Air quality is fine. Normal activities are safe for most people.

51–100 YELLOW

Moderate

People unusually sensitive to smoke, including children, older adults, and people with asthma/COPD or heart disease, should consider reducing prolonged outdoor exertion.

101–150 ORANGE

Unhealthy for sensitive groups

Sensitive groups should avoid prolonged or heavy outdoor exertion; everyone else should consider reducing it, especially if symptoms appear.

151–200 RED

Unhealthy

Everyone should avoid prolonged exertion outdoors. Sensitive groups should stay inside.

201–300 **PURPLE**

Very unhealthy

Everyone should reduce activity, stay indoors in cleaner air if possible, and keep windows closed unless indoor heat creates a bigger immediate danger.

301+ **MAROON**

Hazardous

Emergency conditions. Avoid outdoor exertion. If you must go out and can wear one safely, use a well-fitting N95, KN95, or P100 respirator.

Who is most at risk?

- Children and teenagers (lungs still developing)
- Adults 65 and older
- Pregnant people
- People with asthma, COPD, or other lung diseases
- People with heart disease or diabetes
- Outdoor workers
- People experiencing homelessness or without reliable shelter

Protect yourself and others

- 1 **Check the AQI every morning** during wildfire season. Set alerts on AirNow or your weather app.
- 2 **Stay indoors in cleaner air** with windows and doors closed when smoke is unhealthy, unless indoor heat or another hazard makes that unsafe.
- 3 **Create a clean-air room.** Choose an interior room with few windows. Run an air purifier continuously. Avoid candles, frying, vacuuming, or gas stoves without ventilation.
- 4 **Wear a well-fitting N95, KN95, or P100 respirator** if you must go outside in unhealthy smoke and can wear one safely. Cloth masks do not reliably block PM2.5; respirators may not fit infants/young children and may be difficult for some people with breathing conditions.
- 5 **Consider a Corsi-Rosenthal box.** This DIY air cleaner uses a box fan and MERV-13 or better filters and can substantially reduce indoor particle levels when built and used correctly. Follow current build and electrical-safety guidance; use newer, safety-certified fans where possible; and do not block exits or create trip hazards.
- 6 **Check on vulnerable neighbors daily.** Offer masks, a ride to a clean-air shelter, or help running a filter.
- 7 **Reduce or cancel outdoor events** when AQI is over 150.

For community organizers

ACTION CHECKLIST

- Identify or coordinate **clean-air spaces** with HEPA filtration, safe DIY air cleaners, or other verified filtration.
- **Distribute well-fitting respirators** to outdoor workers and unhoused neighbors, with fit/use caveats and local worker-safety guidance.
- Share AQI alerts via text, social media, and local networks.
- Reschedule outdoor community events when AQI > 150.
- Partner with local libraries, community centers, and faith groups to extend shelter hours.

When to seek medical help

- Difficulty breathing or shortness of breath
- Persistent cough, especially with phlegm or blood
- Chest pain or tightness
- Wheezing that does not improve with medication
- Dizziness or confusion
- Palpitations or irregular heartbeat

Key resources

- **AirNow.gov** — Real-time AQI and fire maps (U.S.)
- **Fire and Smoke Map** — fire.airnow.gov
- **EPA Wildfire Smoke Guide** — epa.gov/pm-pollution/wildfire-smoke-guide-factsheets
- **Corsi-Rosenthal Box build guides** — cleanaircrew.org
- **Emergency** — 911 (U.S./Canada), 112 (Europe), 999 (UK)

Sources: U.S. Environmental Protection Agency (EPA), Centers for Disease Control and Prevention (CDC), World Health Organization (WHO), AirNow, National Weather Service, and published research and public guidance on DIY air filtration. Verify device-building instructions against current safety guidance before use.

This guide is for educational purposes and does not replace professional medical advice. In an emergency, call your local emergency number.